



Available in bright colours, Gucci's latest collection comes with oversized interlocking 'G' detail on the temples

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IMAGINE KEANU REEVES'S 'Neo' in *The Matrix* without his custom-made micro-shades or Tom Cruise's 'Maverick' in *Top Gun* without the fancy aviators or even Audrey Hepburn's 'Holly Golightly' outside Tiffany's in the 1961 romantic comedy *Breakfast at Tiffany's* without her Oliver Goldsmith 'Manhattan' dark glasses. There are certain moments in film history that are unimaginable without sunglasses. Those cool dark shades are almost identifiable with the character.

Sunglasses have been the ultimate stylish accessory since they became available around a century ago. The fact that their main aim is to protect our eyes has become secondary. Sunglasses are worn indoors and in the evening too. They are fashionable and chic and more and more people are spending their disposable income on these highly cool accessories. Consider this: the market for sunglasses was valued at \$21.44 billion in 2021 and is expected to reach \$28.43 billion by 2026, as per Statista Market Insights.

But way before they became

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Audrey Hepburn's character Holly Golightly in *Breakfast at Tiffany's* made the Oliver Goldsmith 'Manhattan' dark glasses popular

trendy, they were used to cover the most telling feature of our face—our eyes. When interrogating witnesses in court, judges in 12th-century China wore flat panes of quartz to conceal their eyes. They maintained an air of impartiality by covering the most expressive part of their faces. Ancient sunglasses provided no sun protection and were only intended to be worn indoors.

It was in the 18th century that tinted spectacles first appeared. Opticians in Venice developed emerald green glasses to protect against the glare of the water. Sunglasses soared in popularity over the following decades. The goggles worn by pilots in the First World War made sunglasses debonair. Hollywood, of course, played its role and dark glasses became associated with celebrities.